

They didn't cancel. Their card did.

Win back the subscribers you're losing without noticing



Source: RevenueCat, State of Subscription Apps 2026.

THE SHORT ANSWER

A big share of your lost subscribers never decided to leave. Their payment failed. On Google Play it's nearly a third of all cancellations.

Turn on the stores' recovery features, **tell users inside the app when their payment has a problem**, ask people why they cancel, and use win-back offers for the ones who left. Most of this is settings, not code.

Getting a new subscriber costs you ads, content and time. Keeping one you already have mostly costs you a few settings and one screen. That's why churn is the cheapest growth there is.

Two kinds of churn

	INVOLUNTARY	VOLUNTARY
What it is	The renewal payment fails: expired card, no balance, bank block	The user decides to cancel
How common	About 1 in 3 cancellations on Google Play, 14% on the App Store	Everything else
How to fix	Store recovery settings + tell the user in the app	Better product, pause options, cancellation feedback, win-back offers

Part 1. Recover failed payments

Google Play

- **Grace period** is on by default. The user keeps access while Google retries the payment
- **Account hold** comes after that. Access pauses but the subscription can still be saved. Since December 2025 its default length is 60 days minus your grace period. **Google says shortening these recovers fewer subscriptions, so leave the defaults on**
- **Show an in-app message** when a payment has a problem. Google Play has a built-in message for this
- **Consider pause.** Letting people pause for a few weeks instead of cancelling keeps some who would otherwise leave

App Store

- **Turn on Billing Grace Period** in App Store Connect. Subscribers keep access for a few days while Apple retries, instead of being cut off the moment a card fails
- **Apple keeps retrying failed payments** for a while after that. Your job is to make sure users know

Both stores

RevenueCat shows who is in a grace period or billing problem. Use that to show a friendly banner in the app:

A BILLING BANNER THAT DOESN'T FEEL LIKE A THREAT

Your payment didn't go through.
Update it to keep your streak and your Pro features.

[Fix payment] [Remind me later]

Part 2. Understand why people cancel

You can't stop people from cancelling. They cancel in the store's settings, not in your app. But you can learn why, and act on it.

- **Ask once, when they cancel.** RevenueCat and the stores tell you when a subscription is set not to renew. Send one short, optional question: "What made you cancel?" with 4 or 5 choices
- **Common answers point to fixes:** "too expensive" means a cheaper plan or pause; "didn't use it" means an onboarding or reminder problem; "missing feature" means your roadmap
- **Never make cancelling hard.** Hiding it or guilt-tripping backfires, and stores and regulators treat it as a dark pattern

📌 My REAL Story

Looked at [SnapPDF](#) revenue one month and saw a drop I could not explain. Nobody had actually cancelled, MRR was just quietly leaking. Dug into RevenueCat and found 23 subscribers in billing retry with no outreach, cards expired or declined and the app just stopped charging them silently. Set up a RevenueCat webhook into my own Firebase, triggered an in app banner that said your card did not go through, tap here to update. Recovered 11 of those 23 in the first week. The scary part is these users still had the app installed and still used it, they just assumed everything was fine because nothing told them otherwise

Part 3. Win back the ones who left

TOOL	WHAT IT DOES
Apple win-back offers	Offers for lapsed subscribers, which Apple can show on your App Store page and in the app. For example, a discounted first month back
Google Play offers for lapsed users	Set up an offer on your base plan and decide yourself who's eligible, such as people who used to subscribe
Email or push	A message a week or two after they leave: what's new, plus the offer

Keep it honest. Tell them what's changed since they left. A discount alone brings people back for one month. A real improvement brings them back for longer.

Part 4. Stop voluntary churn before it starts

- **Push annual plans.** Yearly subscribers stay far longer than monthly or weekly ones
- **Make the first week count.** People who never form a habit with your app cancel at the first renewal
- **Remind them of the value.** "You saved 6 hours this month" before the renewal date, not after
- **Build things worth coming back to:** history, saved work, streaks. It matters even more in AI apps, which RevenueCat's data shows lose annual subscribers faster

What to track every month

NUMBER	WHERE
Involuntary vs voluntary churn	RevenueCat, split by store
Recovered subscriptions from grace period and account hold	RevenueCat or the store consoles
Cancellation reasons	Your survey results

NUMBER	WHERE
Win-back conversions	Store console or RevenueCat, per offer

Checklist

- ☐ Google Play grace period and account hold left on their defaults
- ☐ Billing Grace Period turned on in App Store Connect
- ☐ In-app banner for payment problems
- ☐ Pause option considered on Google Play
- ☐ One-question cancellation survey
- ☐ Win-back offer set up on both stores
- ☐ Monthly check of involuntary vs voluntary churn

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READ [Google Play: subscription payment recovery changes](#)

Official. The 60-day account hold default.

READ [RevenueCat: what's new in Play Billing Library 9](#)

Google's 2026 changes aimed at involuntary churn.

READ [Android Developers: subscription lifecycle](#)

Grace period, account hold and pause, explained.

SEARCH [App store connect billing grace period](#)

Apple's page on turning it on.

SEARCH [Apple win-back offers subscriptions](#)

Apple's guide to setting them up.